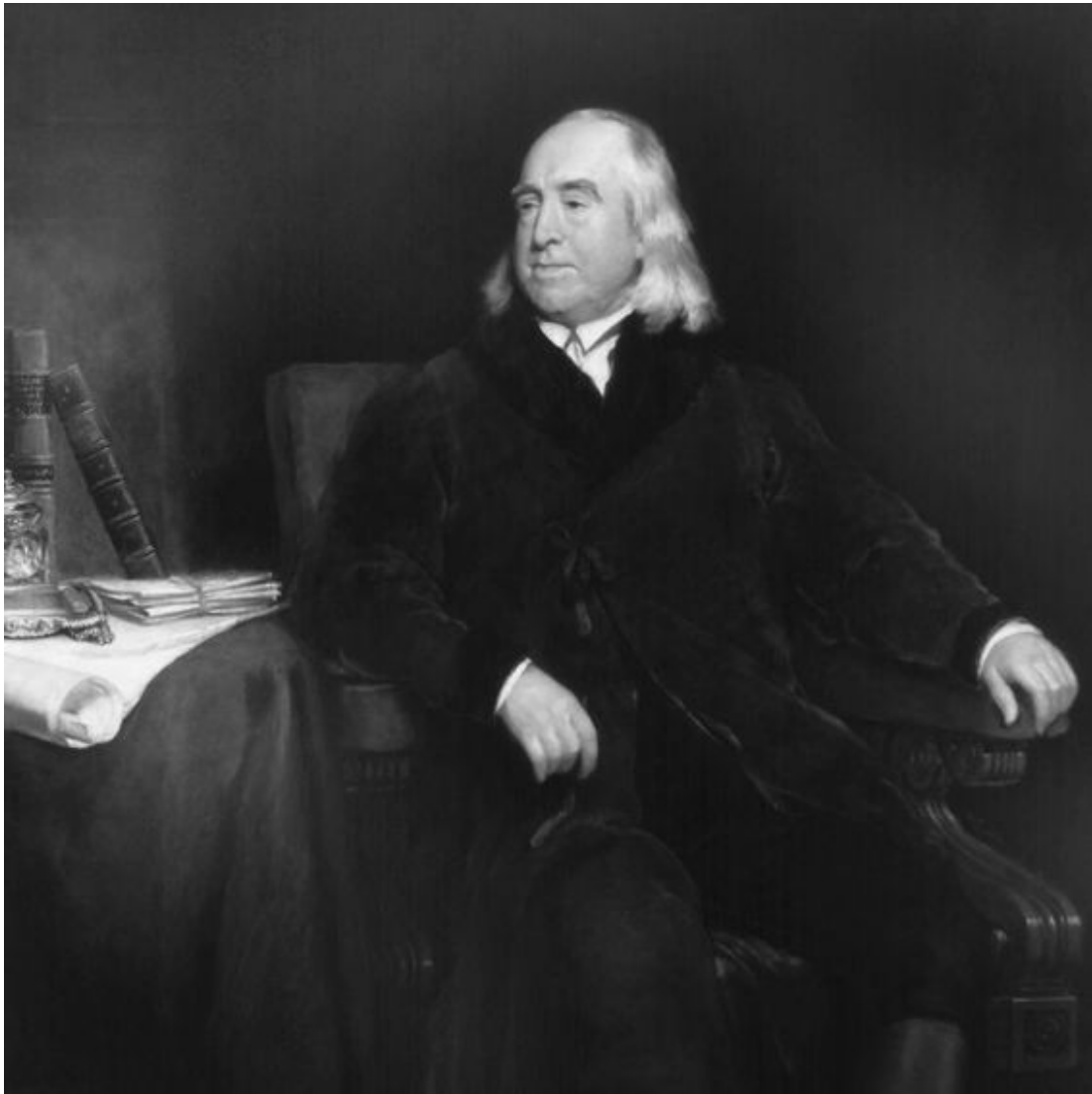


Bentham and utilitarianism



At the end of the 18th century, a movement of ‘freethinkers’ in Britain developed that were influenced as much by pre-revolutionary French political philosophy as they were by British empiricism. Among them was Jeremy Bentham, who proposed a utilitarian system of moral philosophy, in which an action is judged by its usefulness in bringing about beneficial consequences: a morally good action maximizes pleasure and minimizes pain. In quasi-scientific fashion, Bentham devised a ‘calculus of felicity’ in which ‘the greatest happiness of the greatest number ... is the measure of right and wrong’. He applied the same principle to politics, emphasizing

that in his calculus 'everybody is to count for one, and nobody for more than one'. On this basis, many prevailing laws and conventions were seen as unnecessarily authoritarian, especially those concerning personal morality, while laws allowing, for example, exploitation of workers were unduly lax. Bentham's ideas inspired many 19th-century social reforms, and later influenced the foundation of a British socialist movement.